Present-day populists also suffer from the same incoherence that plagued radical anti-establishment movements in previous generations. If power is the only reality, and if information is just a weapon, what does it imply about the populists themselves? Are they too interested only in power, and are they too lying to us to gain power?

Populists have sought to extricate themselves from this conundrum in two different ways. Some populist movements claim adherence to the ideals of modern science and to the traditions of sceptical empiricism. They tell people that indeed you should never trust any institutions or figures of authority – including self-proclaimed populist parties and politicians. Instead, you should 'do your own research' and trust only what you can directly observe by yourself.[25] This radical empiricist position implies that while large-scale institutions like political parties, courts, newspapers and universities can never be trusted, individuals who make the effort can still find the truth by themselves.

This approach may sound scientific and may appeal to free-spirited individuals, but it leaves open the question of how human communities can cooperate to build health-care systems or pass environmental regulations, which demand large-scale institutional organisation. Is a single individual capable of doing all the necessary research to decide whether the earth's climate is heating up and what should be done about it? How would a single person go about collecting climate data from throughout the world, not to mention obtaining reliable records from past centuries? Trusting only 'my own research' may sound scientific, but in practice it amounts to believing that there is no objective truth. As we shall see in chapter 4, science is a collaborative institutional effort rather than a personal quest.

An alternative populist solution is to abandon the modern scientific ideal of finding the truth via 'research' and instead go back to relying on divine revelation or mysticism. Traditional religions like Christianity, Islam and Hinduism have typically characterised humans as untrustworthy power-hungry creatures who can access the truth only thanks to the intervention of a divine intelligence. In the 2010s and early 2020s populist parties from Brazil to Turkey and from the United States to India have aligned themselves with such traditional religions. They have expressed radical doubt about modern institutions while declaring complete faith in ancient scriptures. The populists claim that the articles you read in the *New York*